Topic 3: Biological psychology

Topic overview

Students must show an understanding that biological psychology is about the mechanisms within our body and understand how they affect our behaviour, focusing on aggression.

Individual differences and developmental psychology must be considered when learning about issues such as aggression caused by an accident and how the function of structures of the brain can be affected by the environment.

Subject content	What students need to learn:
3.1 Content	3.1.1 The central nervous system (CNS) and neurotransmitters in human behaviour, including the structure and role of the neuron, the function of neurotransmitters and synaptic transmission. 3.1.2 The effect of recreational drugs on the transmission process in the central nervous system. 3.1.3 The structure of the brain, different brain areas (e.g. pre-frontal cortex) and brain functioning as an explanation of aggression as a human behaviour. 3.1.4 The role of evolution and natural selection to explain human behaviour, including aggression. 3.1.5 Biological explanation of aggression as an alternative to Freud's psychodynamic explanation, referring to the different parts of the personality (id, ego, superego), the importance of the unconscious, and catharsis. 3.1.6 The role of hormones (e.g. testosterone) to explain human behaviour such as aggression.
	3.1.7 Individual differences • Damage to the brain may be affected by individual differences in case studies of brain-damaged patients when it is assumed there are no individual differences. • Freud's view of the personality shows it develops individual differences. 3.1.8 Developmental psychology • The role of evolution in human development. • The role of hormones in human development.